FROM THE

EDITOR-IN-CHIEF

Opinion polls offer fascinating windows into the public mind when you can track variations over time. The India Today-CVoter Mood of the Nation (MOTN) poll for August 2024 has two proximate frames against which to compare its findings. Besides the February data from our bi-annual survey, this is also the first MOTN after the recent Lok Sabha election in May. Its findings broadly align with that mandate of conditional stability but with revealing nuggets about how the public navigates the currents of continuity and change. It reaffirms the helmsmanship of Prime Minister Narendra Modi, qualified on the edges by the rising stock of Rahul Gandhi. If elections were to be held today, the National Democratic Alliance (NDA) would get 299 seats—six more than the 293 it got in the summer. Its vote share, too, would firm up, from 42.5 per cent to 43.7 per cent. The Bharatiya Janata Party (BJP) would also get 244 seats instead of 240—with its vote share inching from 36.5 per cent to 38 per cent. But the party will still be 29 seats short of the 272 needed for a simple majority in the 543-member Lok Sabha. These reiterate the larger message of the general election: while a majority of the voters want Modi to continue as prime minister, conditions do apply. In sync with that, 37 per cent of people think the Lok Sabha results were a vote for continuity, around 14 per cent say it was a vote against the BJP's arrogance and over 12 per cent say they wanted a strong Opposition. Fifty-five per cent believe that this coalition government will run for five years. With the prime minister, resilient layers of popularity ride above a more conditional endorsement on performance metrics. A very creditable 59 per cent find Modi's performance good or outstanding—a minor dip from 61 per cent in February. But break that down, and you find the percentage of people who rate his performance as outstanding has come down from 42 in February to 34 now. Again, while 58 per cent overall are satisfied or very satisfied with the NDA government's performance, a 2 percentage point rise from February, the percentage of people who are very satisfied has come down from 39 to 29. So, while overall the findings are reassuring for the ruling dispensation, there are negative nuances they should be aware of.



February 19, 2024

On the Opposition side, a revelation comes in how the public differentiates between the collective and the singular. The needle dips ever so marginally for the INDIA bloc—from 234 to 232 seats, and 40.6 per cent to 40.3 per cent votes—but the Congress registers a gain. If the MOTN respondents voted now, the party would get 106 seats instead of just 99. Its vote share increase is even meatier: from 21.1 per cent to 25.4 per cent. The distinction sharpens further when trends are isolated at the leader's level. When asked for the leader best suited to become prime minister, a solid 49 per cent plump for Modi, though a 6 percentage point drop from February. But the contrast becomes keener when you juxtapose this against votes for Rahul—22 per cent, a rise of 8 percentage points from the 14 per cent in February, and his second-best score since January 2019 when he was backed by 34 per cent. However, it is important to note that there is still a big 27 percentage point gap between Modi and Rahul, and the Leader of the Opposition has plenty of catching up to do. What is bolstering Rahul's profile, though, is the fact that 32 per cent think he is best suited to lead the Opposition parties, a massive jump from 21 per cent in February. Arvind Kejriwal and Mamata Banerjee see a commensurately significant drop, from 17 and 16 per cent to 6 and 7 per cent, respectively. Clearly, Rahul's visibility as LoP has seen him emerge from the shadows.

Regarding priorities for Modi 3.0, the survey shows that generating more jobs and lowering prices remain the top two issues for the country. As many as 78 per cent of those surveyed say India's unemployment is serious, up from 71 per cent in February. Significantly, 63 per cent of the MOTN respondents say that their current expenses have become difficult to manage. That 52 per cent rate the Modi government's handling of the economy as good or outstanding, compared to 50 per cent in February, means the prime minister is still seen as the best bet to deliver. Here, too, the findings are nuanced: only 20 per cent rate it as outstanding, falling from 32 per cent, while those rating it as good has gone up from 17 to 32 per cent. People are also ambivalent about the new budget's ability to create jobs—45 per cent give it a thumbs-up, 44 per cent think it will not do so. The perception that Modi's economic policies have benefitted big business persists, with 58 per cent of people answering in the affirmative; only 52 per cent said so in February. These findings may seem somewhat contrarian at a time when the country's economy is cruising at a healthy growth rate—8.2 per cent for FY24. Optimism is, however, creeping back. Forecasting for the next six months, 38 per cent feel the economy will improve, a rise from 34 per cent in February, while 29 per cent feel their incomes will increase as against 25 per cent earlier.

The MOTN survey has interesting insights on a range of topical issues. Yogi Adityanath remains the most popular chief minister nationally, followed by Kejriwal, Mamata and Stalin. Yogi's popularity, though, drops from 46 per cent in February to 33 per cent now. The Grand Old Party should note with concern that no Congress chief minister figures among the top 10 most popular CMs in their home states. On other issues, as many as 87 per cent want legally guaranteed MSP for farm produce; 65 per cent may back the Agnipath scheme but 38 per cent want improvements; 53 per cent endorse the new criminal laws but 31 per cent want more checks; 51 per cent prefer diplomatic options vis-a-vis Pakistan, only 33 per cent want war or surgical strikes; and the caste census joins the Uniform Civil Code and One Nation, One Poll as issues that get over 70 per cent backing. The poll also reflects a renewed optimism about the state of Indian democracy. A notable 50 per cent now believe that democracy is not in danger, up from 39 per cent in February.

As Modi and the BJP continue to dominate the political landscape, the message to all sides is that India seeks betterment but values stability over upheaval.

(Aroon Purie)